Circulation

Sampling independent work and responding

Use circulation to read learning across the room, identify the exact error and choose a response. Move with a route and a diagnostic focus rather than following raised hands alone.

How to do it well

1 Plan the route. Identify the success criterion, likely errors and pupils you must see, with a path that covers every area.

2 Observe first attempts. After securing the launch, inspect early work before students repeat the process many times.

3 Diagnose the response. Read the relevant section and ask a brief question where the reasoning is unclear.

4 Give a bounded next action. Use a prompt, clue or direct explanation according to need, then require the pupil to do the thinking.

5 Revisit and decide. Check the change; preserve productive work where gaps are isolated, or pause the class when the pattern justifies reteaching.

What this sounds like

“I am checking the reason you chose this method. Show me that decision. Fix this line, then try the next item; I will return shortly.”

Classroom example. During essay practice, the teacher’s route checks the claim–evidence link in selected first paragraphs across the room. Quick notes distinguish missing evidence from weak explanation. Some pupils receive an individual prompt; a shared pattern becomes a brief class model. The teacher returns to inspect the changed sentence before continuing the route.

Top tips that make the technique work

Inspect one feature at a time. Look for the first decision, selected evidence or a specific presentation feature so the scan stays purposeful.

Include likely invisible pupils. Deliberately visit students whose work or thinking you do not normally hear.

Visit strong work early too. It helps establish the expected standard and can supply an exemplar for later discussion.

Keep the whole room visible. Step back between individual interactions; avoid becoming absorbed at one desk.

Record patterns briefly. A quick note or seating-plan mark helps distinguish an individual gap from a class-wide issue.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Use scan, read and compare with the criterion.	Wandering without a focus.
Return after a targeted intervention.	Explaining at length beside one pupil while losing the rest of the room.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Circulation and Actionable Feedback | Barton - Participation during independent practice